Providing language support pathways for students

Practical guide for institutions | I03

Ensure that students who need additional support can access provision suited to their course demands. A referral should lead to an accessible service and a clear next step, with follow-up where needed.

Using this guide: Use existing academic support, referral and progress-monitoring processes. This guide adds a focus on language-related barriers in EMI and does not replace institutional procedures or service responsibilities.

1. Map available provision and identify gaps

Identify what the institution currently offers, who can access it and how it connects to EMI study. Distinguish between:

- Subject teaching and clarification.
- Academic skills support, such as reading, assignment planning and using evidence.
- English-language provision for continuing language development.
- Specialist services addressing accessibility, digital access or wellbeing.

Check whether provision covers needs throughout the program. Identify gaps rather than assuming that a general study-skills workshop can address every language difficulty.

Provision may include individual tutoring, focused workshops, continuing academic English courses and support with disciplinary tasks such as lab reports or business recommendations. Match the format, timing and intensity to identified needs; no single option will suit every student.

2. Define clear routes into support

Explain how students can seek help themselves and how educators can make referrals. For each route, specify the contact, booking steps, eligibility, any cost and what students should bring.

Provide a straightforward starting point for students who are unsure which service they need. Staff should help identify the appropriate route rather than repeatedly redirecting the student.

3. Match support to the identified need

Use evidence from course tasks and discussion with the student to select an appropriate response.

For example, difficulty organising a report may call for academic skills support. Persistent difficulty understanding or producing English across tasks may require specialist language assessment and sustained provision. Some students will need both.

A referral should describe the task and difficulty without making an unsupported diagnosis.

4. Make support accessible to ethnic-minority students

Check whether information about support is understandable and whether booking processes, timing, location, cost or connectivity create barriers.

Where feasible, provide explanations or initial contact in relevant ethnic-minority languages. Vietnamese may also be useful but should not be assumed to be every student's strongest language. Consult students about what would help, without requiring them to disclose or represent a particular community.

Make clear that seeking support is a normal part of university study. Do not assume classmates can interpret sensitive information or act as informal support staff.

5. Coordinate support with course learning

Enable subject educators and language specialists to work together on relevant demands, such as explaining a calculation, reading disciplinary texts or justifying a recommendation.

Agree what information needs to be shared and follow institutional requirements for consent and confidentiality. Support should help students develop their own capabilities while maintaining disciplinary outcomes and assessment standards.

Provide staff time and resources for coordination rather than relying solely on individual goodwill.

6. Follow up and address unmet needs

Agree who will check whether the student reached the service and whether the response was suitable. Where appropriate, agree a practice goal and a review point with the student.

If provision is unavailable, inaccessible or insufficient, identify an alternative or escalate the gap to the responsible institutional lead. Repeating the same referral is unlikely to resolve a lack of provision.

7. Example moving beyond a general workshop

A student attends a report-writing workshop but continues to struggle with understanding readings and expressing relationships between ideas in English.

With the student's involvement, an adviser reviews examples of the difficulty and arranges specialist language input. The subject educator identifies upcoming reading and writing demands so that support can connect to course learning.

The team agrees on a manageable practice plan and a follow-up point. The educator continues to provide clear teaching and task guidance; the referral does not transfer all responsibility to the support service.

8. Review checklist

☐ Available provision and gaps are documented.

☐ Students and educators know how to access each pathway.

☐ Referrals describe specific needs and relevant course tasks.

☐ Access barriers for ethnic-minority students are considered.

☐ Subject teaching and specialist support are coordinated.

☐ Someone follows up on unsuccessful referrals and unmet needs.

9. When classroom practice is insufficient

Additional provision is needed when students continue to experience significant language barriers despite appropriate classroom support. Institutions should determine the type, intensity and duration of support required with relevant specialists. Optional self-study resources alone should not be treated as a sufficient response to every identified need.

10.Related toolkit guidance

I02: identifying student language and learning support needs. D14: accessing digital resources. D16: learning experiences and support preferences. D17: finding and accessing additional support.

11.Supporting sources

Galloway, N., & Sahan, K. (2021). An investigation into English Medium Instruction in higher education in Thailand and Vietnam. British Council. Open source

Section 9, particularly “Language support”, supports provision informed by institutional and departmental needs analysis, connected to content learning and available throughout study. The report also discusses collaboration between subject and language educators.

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing & Professional Studies. (n.d.). Fostering a Linguistically Inclusive and Asset-Based Classroom. Open source

The “Helpful Tips” section supports recognising students’ linguistic resources and inclusive multilingual communication. Applying these principles to ethnic-minority students’ initial access to support services is a toolkit adaptation.

Galloway, N. (Ed.). (2020). English in higher education – English medium. Part 1: Literature review. British Council. Open source

Pages 44–50 discuss individual tutoring, workshops, continuing courses, discipline-specific provision and the timing of support. These options inform the guide’s provision examples.

The pathway design, referral and follow-up steps, access checks, example and checklist are toolkit adaptations for Vietnamese higher education. The sources support particular principles rather than the complete guide. This is a developing draft, not a validated service model; implementation and effectiveness with ethnic-minority students require local review.